



**Food and Agriculture
Organization of the
United Nations**



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Context

South Sudan is facing one of the most severe food insecurity crises globally. According to the latest Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) analysis, 55 percent of the population is experiencing high levels of acute food insecurity (IPC Phase 3 or above), including 73 000 people in Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5).¹ Additionally, four counties – Akobo and Nyirol in Jonglei State and Luakpiny/Nasir and Ulang in Upper Nile State – face a risk of Famine under a probable worst-case scenario, which has a realistic likelihood of occurring.

The crisis is driven by a combination of recurrent shocks and structural vulnerabilities. Four consecutive years of severe flooding have destroyed crops, livestock and critical infrastructure, significantly undermining agricultural production and livelihoods. Concurrently, protracted conflict and insecurity continue to restrict humanitarian access, displace communities and disrupt local economies.

Since the start of the conflict in the Sudan in April 2023, South Sudan has experienced a massive influx of over 700 000 returnees and refugees.² More than 70 percent have settled in already vulnerable areas where FAO is providing support, placing additional strain on limited resources and services. This is compounded by a deteriorating economic situation characterized by currency depreciation, rising food prices and disrupted markets, further eroding households' purchasing power.

These shocks are occurring in a context of widespread structural poverty and limited livelihood diversification, leaving households with minimal coping capacity and highly vulnerable to further deterioration.

The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) is scaling up its response to enable vulnerable families to produce and access nutritious food, protect their livelihoods and prevent further hunger and malnutrition. Under the **South Sudan: Emergency and Resilience Plan, 2026–2028**, FAO requires USD 255 million to support 5.25 million people. Of this amount, an initial USD 10 million is urgently needed to deliver time-critical, life-saving agricultural interventions to 1.8 million people.

South Sudan

**Protecting livelihoods
and preventing famine**

Urgent call for assistance



FAO requires
USD 10 million



To assist
1.8 million people



Period
May–September 2026



Targeted areas
**Priority counties
within all ten states**

FAO's life-saving agriculture response

Activities implemented and funding received so far

FAO, in collaboration with its local partners, is delivering emergency livelihood support to the most vulnerable households across the country. Under the current funding envelope of approximately USD 3.5 million – comprising USD 1.62 million from the South Sudan Humanitarian Fund, USD 140 000 from the Government of Japan, and approximately USD 1.7 million from savings and carry-over from previous projects – FAO is supporting an estimated 103 000 households (approximately 564 000 people) countrywide. A further 9 420 households in Unity State are being reached thanks to funding from the Governments of Norway and the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland.

The Organization's current response spans 25 counties across eight states (Central Equatoria, Eastern Equatoria, Jonglei, Northern Bahr el Ghazal, Upper Nile, Unity, Warrap and Western Bahr el Ghazal), with a strategic focus on the locations with the highest levels of vulnerability. FAO is operational in two of the six counties where communities are experiencing Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) (Luakpiny/Nasir and Ulang), supporting 13 333 households in the most critical areas.

Assistance is currently being delivered to the 103 000 households through the following interventions:

- **Seed fairs (cash/voucher modality):** Approximately 8 000 households are receiving support through seed fairs, enabling them to select their preferred seeds from local markets while strengthening local food systems.
- **Direct input packages:** The remaining 95 000 households are receiving livelihood support packages comprising crop seeds (groundnut, maize and sorghum), vegetable seeds (amaranth, collard, okra, onion and tomato), one hand tool per household, and fishing kits to diversify their food sources.
- **Livestock support:** Current interventions also include the vaccination and treatment of approximately 200 000 animals, safeguarding the livestock assets of agro/pastoral households.

Scaling up to reach 1.8 million people in need

FAO aims to scale up its emergency livelihood response to reach vulnerable people in the most food-insecure areas during the critical 2026 agricultural season. Additional resources would enable FAO to more than triple its current reach, providing a comprehensive, multi-sector package of crop, fisheries and livestock support to communities at the highest risk of Famine.

Situation analysis



7.8 million people facing high levels of acute food insecurity (IPC Phase 3 or above) between April and July 2026, including 73 306 people in Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5)¹



2.2 million children under 5 years of age and 1.2 million pregnant or breastfeeding women suffering from acute malnutrition¹



+304 000 people displaced by violence in Jonglei State since December 2025³



+80% of people live in rural areas and rely on agriculture for food and income

The window to act is rapidly closing. Unless agricultural inputs reach farmers by June, the main planting seasons will be lost. We know what must be done; delaying action will only deepen the crisis, drive up response costs and increase humanitarian needs for millions.

Table 1. Breakdown of planned interventions

Sector	Urgent action	Impact	Target	Cost per household (USD)	Cost per sector (USD)
Crops	URGENT – June 2026 cut-off. Emergency distribution of crop seeds (sorghum, maize, groundnut, cowpea and sesame), vegetable seeds (amaranth, collard, eggplant, okra, onion and tomato), and one hand tool per household	Enable food production during the main planting season	200 000 households	25	5 000 000
	Market-based seed support through seed fairs (cash and vouchers) in counties with functioning markets	Ensure household agency and stimulate local agricultural trade			
Fisheries	Provision of nets, hooks, fishing lines and safety equipment to fishing households in flood-prone areas (including Jonglei, Unity and Upper Nile states)	Sustain critical sources of protein and income during the lean season	50 000 households	40	2 000 000
Livestock	Vaccination and treatment of approximately 3 million cattle and small ruminants against contagious bovine pleuropneumonia, foot and-mouth disease, peste des petits ruminants, haemorrhagic septicaemia, blackleg, and internal and external parasites	Protect the primary livelihood asset and food source of pastoral communities	3 million animals belonging to 50 000 households	50	2 500 000
Operations	Transport, logistics, monitoring and evaluation, and staff support	Enable the delivery of urgent assistance	All areas	5% of total cost of intervention	500 000
Total			300 000 households	–	10 000 000

Source: Authors' own elaboration.

The cost of inaction

Without immediate and scaled-up support, the humanitarian consequences will be severe, irreversible within the season, and likely to drive a further deterioration in IPC classification across multiple counties. FAO warns of the following cascading impacts if funding is not mobilized before the June 2026 planting deadline:

1. Expansion of areas facing Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) and risk of Famine

Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) is currently documented in six counties across Upper Nile and Jonglei states, affecting over 73 000 people. However, the structural drivers – persistent flooding, conflict, displacement and market failures – remain unaddressed across a much wider geographic area. Without emergency livelihood interventions during the current planting season, the following projections apply:

- Counties currently in Emergency (IPC Phase 4), including Rubkona in Unity, Malakal in Upper Nile, and Canal/Pigi, Duk, Ayod and Pibor in Jonglei, face a high risk of deteriorating into Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) conditions during the June–September 2026 lean season.
- The 2.49 million people currently in Emergency (IPC Phase 4) are one missed harvest away from catastrophe. A failed main season will eliminate their primary domestic food source and erode any residual coping capacity.
- An estimated additional 500 000–700 000 people could slide into Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) by the second half of 2026 if no emergency agricultural support is provided.

2. Missed agricultural season with irreversible impacts within a year

Table 2. Breakdown of the projected consequences of not providing emergency agricultural support

If we don't act by June 2026	Projected consequences
No crop seeds provided	200 000+ households miss the main planting window entirely, resulting in no domestic food production for 12 months
No fishing kits distributed	50 000+ fishing households lose access to a vital source of protein and income during the peak fishing season, and post harvest losses increase
No livestock vaccination	3 million animals are at risk of preventable disease outbreaks, and livestock mortality erodes the primary wealth and food asset of pastoral communities
No seed fairs conducted	Local seed markets collapse, informal seed networks are disrupted, and community resilience is further degraded
No intervention in IPC 5 areas	16 484 people in Luakpiny/Nasir County and 7 656 in Ulang County face deepening Famine with no domestic food production fallback

Source: Authors' own elaboration.

3. Multiplier effects on agrifood systems and markets

- Failure to support the current planting season will drive increased dependence on food assistance programmes, placing additional pressure on already-strained World Food Programme and non-governmental organization pipelines.
- Livestock losses from preventable disease outbreaks are irreversible within a season and take years to rebuild, permanently reducing community resilience and productive capacity.
- Market disruption resulting from livelihood collapse will further inflate local food prices, disproportionately affecting the urban poor and displaced populations in Juba, Malakal and Renk – cities already hosting large IPC 3+ populations.

4. Returnee and refugee pressure

Since April 2023, large numbers of returnees and refugees have entered South Sudan from the Sudan, with most settling in counties covered by current and proposed FAO interventions, particularly in Renk (Upper Nile State), where nearly 377 000 people are already in IPC Phase 3+. This sustained influx places extraordinary pressure on host community agrifood systems. Without scaled-up support, host communities will exhaust their remaining coping mechanisms, triggering inter-community tensions and leading to further displacement.

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Notes

- ¹ **IPC.** 2026. *South Sudan: IPC Acute food insecurity and malnutrition snapshot, April–July 2026*. Juba. https://www.ipcinfo.org/fileadmin/user_upload/ipcinfo/docs/IPC_SouthSudan_Projection_update_Acute_Food_Insecurity_Malnutrition_April_July2026_Snapshot.pdf
- ² **UNHCR (UN Refugee Agency).** 2026. Sudan situation. In: *Operational data portal*. [Cited 15 May 2026]. <https://data.unhcr.org/en/situations/sudansituation>
- ³ **OCHA (United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs).** 2026. *South Sudan Humanitarian Update 18–30 April 2026*. Juba. <https://www.unocha.org/publications/report/south-sudan/south-sudan-humanitarian-update-18-30-april-2026>

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